

he knew how much I loved him, at sixteen I didn't know how proud of him I should've been. To overcome the addictions he had to drugs, alcohol, and cigarettes was remarkable enough. And then to replace them with healthy habits like exercise was something no one told him to do, no one around him was doing it, he just did it. When he got too sick to cycle, he'd still wake up every morning at 5 a.m. and write fun little notes to me and my mom. He made it all look natural.

Today, when I think of him, the first thing I think about isn't the family vacations or things we did. I think of lying in bed hearing the whir of the stationary bike in the front room. I think of his character that was consistent and kind whether privately at home or out in public with acquaintances or friends. He was the barometer by which I measured what I was capable of, and he gave me the unspoken permission I needed to believe I'm capable of anything. But it didn't happen immediately.

There have been times in my life I've wanted to change something, but I didn't want to change too drastically from the people around me. I didn't want people to think I was too big for my britches, that I was trying too hard, and I definitely didn't want them to admire or think too highly of me. I was hesitant to look for a community that did things differently, because where would I find them? That was scary, you never know what you're gonna get, and I didn't want to hurt my current friends' feelings. I wanted to fit in more than I wanted to improve. It took years after my dad's passing to realize what he had done. To realize what he risked by doing things differently and how what he gained was so worth it. And it gave me permission to make changes in my life, better late than never.

We all have someone in our lives who has given us permission: to believe something, do something, or become something greater than we believe for ourselves. Not explicit approval, but a silent signal that it's okay, to come on in, the water's fine. Whenever my dad wanted to do something, he did it. Whether it was quit smoking, lose weight, or whatever, he was not the man to sit around and complain. His first instinct was to take action. If you know me personally, you know I take the same approach to life now, whether it's starting a blog, recording a podcast, or writing a book. In fact, this book might never have happened without someone's permission.

I'd always wanted to walk into a bookstore and see my name on a book, but I didn't think our platform was big enough. When I shared my dream with my friend John, who'd recently published a book, he told me my ideas